

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Insurance English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For underwriters, claims adjusters, brokers, risk managers, actuarial analysts, policy-service teams, compliance staff, and insurance operations leaders.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

adjuster

A person who investigates and evaluates an insurance claim.

appeal

A request for a decision to be reviewed through an established process.

claim

A statement that may need evidence, approval, qualification, or disclosure before it is used externally.

complaint

An expression of dissatisfaction requiring attention under a relevant process.

corrective action

Action taken to fix a current problem and prevent recurrence.

coverage

The protection provided by an insurance policy; in telecommunications, the area with service availability.

coverage position

An insurer's stated interpretation of how policy coverage applies to a claim.

deductible

The amount a policyholder bears before the insurer pays covered amounts as the policy specifies.

denial

Decision by an insurer, payer, regulator, or authority not to approve, pay, or grant a requested item or claim.

endorsement

A document that changes an insurance policy's terms.

exclusion

Something outside an agreed scope or expressly not covered by a policy or agreement.

exposure

The extent to which people, assets, or operations are subject to a hazard or potential loss.

fraud indicator

An observation that may warrant investigation but does not by itself prove fraud.

frequency

How often an event occurs within a stated population or period.

investigation

A systematic effort to establish facts and understand an event or concern.

loss development

Changes in estimated or reported insurance losses as more information becomes available over time.

loss history

A record of prior claims or losses for an insured risk.

market conduct

How an insurer or financial firm treats customers and carries out market-facing activities.

material misrepresentation

A false or misleading statement significant to a decision under applicable law or contract terms.

policy

Formal rule or standard that guides decisions and behavior.

premium

The price charged for insurance coverage over a stated period.

proof of loss

Information or a formal statement supporting an insurance loss claim as required by the process.

reinsurance

Insurance purchased by an insurer to transfer an agreed part of its risk.

renewal

Continuation of a policy, contract, or subscription for a further period.

reservation of rights

An insurer's notice preserving specified coverage positions while a matter is reviewed, subject to applicable law.

reserve

Resources set aside for a purpose; in insurance, an estimate of amounts needed for obligations.

reserve adequacy

Whether estimated insurance reserves are sufficient for the obligations they are intended to cover.

risk appetite

The amount and types of risk an organization is prepared to pursue or retain.

severity

The seriousness of an event, impact, or loss under stated criteria.

SIU

Special investigation unit: an insurance team examining claims or concerns that need specialist investigation.

timely communication

Providing information early enough to meet the relevant need or required process.

underwriting

Evaluation of risk and terms used to decide whether and on what conditions to issue insurance, extend credit, or accept an investment exposure.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Underwriting and Risk Selection

An underwriting submission describes a business activity broadly but omits its operating locations and loss history.

Could you confirm the activities, locations, and requested loss-history information? Those details will help the underwriting team assess the submission without relying on assumptions about the business.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

02 | Policy Language and Coverage Interpretation

A client sees a policy summary and assumes it includes every term of coverage. The full policy has endorsements and exclusions.

The summary is an overview. The actual policy wording, including endorsements and exclusions, needs to be reviewed for the coverage question. Let's identify the relevant documents and ask the appropriate specialist to clarify them.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

03 | Claims Intake and Reserving

A claim report lacks the event date and supporting documents. The intake team needs a clear follow-up request.

Could you provide the event date and the requested supporting records through the secure channel? If an item is unavailable, please tell us so the claim team can explain the next step.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

04 | Coverage Disputes and Denials

A client asks whether a reported loss is definitely covered. The claim review is still underway.

The coverage review is still underway, so I cannot confirm the outcome. I can explain what information has been received, what remains outstanding, and how the team will communicate its decision.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

05 | Broker and Client Renewal Meetings

A renewal quote has a lower premium but a higher deductible. The client asks whether it is the same protection for less money.

The premium is lower, but the deductible has changed. We should compare the coverage terms and other differences as well before describing the options as equivalent.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

06 | Fraud Indicators and SIU Referral

An unusual claim pattern prompts concern. A note calls the customer fraudulent before an investigation has established the facts.

The pattern is an indicator for review, not proof of fraud. I'll describe the observed facts neutrally and route the concern through the appropriate investigation process.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

07 | Actuarial Assumptions and Pricing

An actuarial update shows claim costs rising because both the number of claims and average cost per claim increased.

Both frequency and severity contributed to the increase. I'll show the number of claims separately from their average cost so the audience can understand the two drivers.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

08 | Compliance, Market Conduct, and Complaints

A policyholder's complaint received a generic reply that did not address a specific fee question.

Our earlier reply did not answer your fee question. I'm sorry. I'll record that point for review and explain the next step and expected update under our complaints process.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.